The official announcement by the government in early January 2012 that the NLD and Aung San Suu Kyi would be permitted to run in the 2012 elections was a monumental step forward. Suu Kyi also began to travel again in early 2012. Her popularity had not waned as large crowds gathered at every opportunity to meet “the lady.” This decision gave the Myanmar government greater legitimacy both internally and externally. The process culminated in Suu Kyi's decision to run for a seat in the Myanmar parliament in April 2012. Her subsequent election further legitimized the process of reconciliation between the regime and opposition leaders. In addition to Suu Kyi, the NLD won 40 seats in parliament. Even though the NLD' s power in parliament is still insignificant, this is the first time they will have a seat at the policymaking table. Statements from the NLD and Aung San Suu Kyi said that further transparency in government activities as well as a sincere push to end ethnic strife in Myanmar needed to be high priorities for the regime. Finally, an effort to push for a Panglong type of conference (similar to the one held in 1947) could help iron out differences among the groups still involved in conflict.

In late April, United Nations Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon made a historic visit to Myanmar to address the parliament. He was the first foreigner to address the legislature since 1962. The main points emphasized by the secretary-general included the need for international assistance and a new commitment from the global community to engage with the government. Ban Ki-moon held meetings with both Thein Sein and Aung San Suu Kyi.

On May 17, 2012, President Barack Obama announced the easing of an investment ban and the naming of the first U.S. ambassador to Myanmar in 22 years. President Obama's statement said that the moves were a reward for democratic reforms implemented in recent months. Aung San Suu Kyi's election to parliament in April was a major impetus for the decision. Secretary of State Clinton stated that the United States was suspending sanctions on export of American financial services and investment across all sectors of the Myanmar economy. This included the resource-rich lucrative oil, gas, and mining sectors. The final agreement was signed after Clinton held meetings with Myanmar Foreign Minister Wunna Maung Lwin. Clinton stated, “Today we say to American business, invest in Burma, and do it responsibly.” Clinton announced that Derek Mitchell, the